


# The Role of Emotions and Subjective Attitudes in Mobilization and Changes in the Dynamics of Protests against the "Russian Law"

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**Significance of the Study**

The protests against the "Russian law" in Georgia provide the setting for examining how emotions shape collective action. Emotions permeate all of social life, including social movements. They are not only our responses to particular events but also shape the goals of our actions. Emotions may be positive or negative, inspiring or demotivating, public or concealed, and so forth. Social life is inconceivable without emotions, particularly when discussing social movements. Although emotions undoubtedly influence every aspect of social life, their influence on social movements is especially significant. Social movements emerge to challenge established norms, and this opposition evokes various emotions among participants.[1]

Traditionally, social movement theory focused on cognitive aspects, such as ideas and beliefs, while giving less attention to the role of emotions in motivating participation and shaping movement dynamics. Gradually, however, researchers have increasingly recognized the crucial role of emotions in motivating participation, shaping movement dynamics, and influencing outcomes. The recent growth of research on emotions can be attributed to several factors. These include the "cultural turn" in the social sciences, which opened up space for studying emotions alongside cultural factors such as identity and shared meaning. This approach allows sociology to develop a more detailed understanding of emotions as products of both individual and social influences.

Earlier literature on collective behavior portrayed institutional politics as the domain of reason and viewed protest negatively as driven by emotions and, therefore, irrationality. In response, a subsequent generation of scholars recognized the rationality of movement participants and examined their emotions. Research on emotions offers a multifaceted account of human experience, treating emotions as pervasive features of social life and emphasizing their importance for collective action and, specifically, changes in protest dynamics.[2]

Our study examines this complex relationship between emotions and social movements through the protests against the "Russian law" outside Parliament in Tbilisi, Georgia. We go beyond studying emotions simply as reactions to events and examine their capacity to shape the goals of social movements. Different emotions play different roles in demonstrations. Examining how emotions change protest dynamics and the actions of social movements requires attention to

[1] James M. Jasper, "The Emotions of Protest: Affective and Reactive Emotions In and Around Social Movements," Sociological Forum 13, no. 3 (1998): 397–424.

[2] Jeff Goodwin, James M. Jasper, and Francesca Polletta, eds., *Passionate Politics: Emotions and Social Movements* (University of Chicago Press, 2001).

the relationship between particular emotions and mobilization, as well as to how these emotions contribute to changes in the course of a protest.

We became interested in the protests against the “Russian law,” which were a particularly prominent issue in Georgia at the time of the study. The wave of protests continued unabated, participant numbers changed daily, and streets were blocked, indicating the mass character of the demonstrations. These developments drew our attention to events in the country and led us to investigate the role of emotions in the dynamics of the ongoing protests.

Because emotions are powerful motivators, analyzing their influence on participation in demonstrations can shed light on what prompts individuals to take action and sustains their involvement. Emotions do more than generate protest: they also shape its character. This study considers both emotions, such as anger, fear, and disappointment, and underlying attitudes, including beliefs about national sovereignty, democracy, and Russian influence. These attitudes shape the nature and content of emotions and participants’ activity or passivity. By examining this dynamic interaction between emotions and social movements, our study seeks to develop a deeper understanding of the forces underlying collective action and social change.

We used a qualitative, ethnographic approach combining participant observation, four ethnographic interviews, and ten semi-structured interviews. The sampling procedures, interview formats, and observational activities are described in the methodology section.

Based on the above, our main research question is:

- What role do emotions play in mobilization and changes in the dynamics of protests against the “Russian law”?

Subquestions:

- What emotions do protest participants experience?
- Which emotions encourage greater activity in the protest movement, and which encourage passivity?
- How do these emotions change alongside protest dynamics?

**Literature Review**

In *The Emotions of Protest*, James Jasper distinguishes categories of emotion and examines their different effects on social movements and protest. His discussion of short-lived reflex emotions, in contrast to more enduring feelings and moods, is particularly relevant to distinguishing the emotional patterns in our data.[3] This distinction raises a specific question for our case: how can an initially immediate reaction become part of the sustained emotional background of a protest?

Jasper's discussion identifies ways in which emotions such as anger and disgust can either disrupt or support mobilization. Uncontrolled anger may interfere with strategic action, but this does not mean that anger necessarily makes a crowd irrational.[4] Similarly, although disgust is a negative emotion, it may contribute to mobilization, and organizers may seek to intensify it.[5] These differentiated accounts provide a basis for comparing the effects described in the literature with those observed in the protests against the "Russian law." Our study examines whether these emotions remained brief reactions or helped sustain participation over time, thereby identifying how their effects operated in this particular case.

Van Stekelenburg and Klandermans show why attention to emotions matters for understanding participation in protest: demands for change begin with grievances. These may involve experiences of illegitimate inequality, a sense of being in the minority, perceived injustice, moral outrage at a particular situation, or newly emerging resentment.[6]

In "Emotions and Social Movements: Twenty Years of Theory and Research," James Jasper again examines the role and influence of emotions in social movements and protests. Connecting emotions to movement dynamics helps clarify their broader effects. Jasper identifies emotions as important individual motivators that shape both the stated and unstated goals of social movements. They can therefore affect mobilization, existing strategies, and a movement's success.[7]

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[3] James M. Jasper, *The Emotions of Protest* (University of Chicago Press, 2018), 25.
[4] James M. Jasper, *The Emotions of Protest* (University of Chicago Press, 2018), 43.
[5] James M. Jasper, *The Emotions of Protest* (University of Chicago Press, 2018), 47.
[6] Jacquelien van Stekelenburg and Bert Klandermans, "Individuals in Movements: A Social Psychology of Contention," in *Handbook of Social Movements Across Disciplines*, ed. Conny Roggeband and Bert Klandermans, 2nd ed. (Springer, 2017), 103–140. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-319-57648-0_5
[7] James M. Jasper, "Emotions and Social Movements: Twenty Years of Theory and Research," Annual Review of Sociology 37 (2011): 285–303.

Jasper describes how different emotions can shape the course of a movement in different ways. Two categories are particularly relevant here: reflex emotions, which involve rapid, automatic responses to information, such as fear, surprise, disgust, and joy; and moral emotions, which involve approval or disapproval grounded in moral intuitions and principles, such as shame, guilt, pride, and compassion.[8] Reflex emotions may sometimes prompt actions that disrupt movement strategies, although their effects depend on the circumstances.[9] For the protests examined here, this distinction directs attention to changes in participants' emotions and to how those changes were associated with their actions. It also helps identify which emotions hindered the course of a demonstration and which helped people unite.

Emotions can arise spontaneously, but they can also be deliberately cultivated. Jasper's cultural approach emphasizes the importance of culture for understanding emotions in politics.[10] Movement organizers may, for example, seek to create moral shocks that draw more people into participation. This literature therefore highlights the need to examine what protesters responded to, which factors changed their emotions, and how these changes affected their involvement. It provides a more specific basis for identifying the emotions that were dominant in mobilization and for tracing their relationship with changes in protest dynamics.

Jasper also uses the term "moral battery" to describe how the contrast and interaction between negative and positive emotions can motivate action.[11] An emotion may be intensified when it is compared with its opposite, just as a battery operates through the tension between its positive and negative poles.[12] This concept is relevant to our study because it raises the question of whether different emotions alternated during the protests or whether one type predominated. It also directs attention to how these emotional combinations affected participants' actions, sustained their energy, and shaped the course of the demonstrations.

The volume *Research Agendas in the Sociology of Emotions*, edited by Theodore Kemper, addresses related issues and raises a question central to our study: what holds society

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[8] James M. Jasper, "Emotions and Social Movements: Twenty Years of Theory and Research," Annual Review of Sociology 37 (2011): 285–303.
[9] James M. Jasper, "Emotions and Social Movements: Twenty Years of Theory and Research," Annual Review of Sociology 37 (2011): 285–303.
[10] James M. Jasper, "Emotions and Social Movements: Twenty Years of Theory and Research," Annual Review of Sociology 37 (2011): 285–303.
[11] James M. Jasper, "Emotions and Social Movements: Twenty Years of Theory and Research," Annual Review of Sociology 37 (2011): 291.
[12] James M. Jasper, "Emotions and Social Movements: Twenty Years of Theory and Research," Annual Review of Sociology 37 (2011): 291.

together? One answer is moral solidarity, which develops through emotional processes.[13] The volume discusses the contagious quality of emotions: people gradually share one another's feelings, which can then become stronger and more dominant.[14] The theories of Goffman and Durkheim emphasize solidarity and a sense of membership,[15] both of which relate directly to the reasons for, and purposes of, participation in a social movement.

*Political Emotions*, edited by Janet Staiger, Ann Cvetkovich, and Ann Reynolds, is another relevant contribution. The volume examines emotions in the political sphere, including how they are communicated and framed and how they influence public discourse, social movements, and political action. It considers the relationship between emotions, public discourse, and the media, as well as how emotions are evaluated politically, including why some are considered legitimate for public expression while others are not.

The volume includes critical analyses of political speeches, media representations, and other cultural texts, alongside studies of social movements and political activism that examine how emotions are used to mobilize and motivate people. It also explores the relationship between emotions and politics theoretically. Its engagement with earlier accounts of crowds, including Le Bon's work, challenges the opposition between rational institutional politics and supposedly irrational, emotional protest. Subsequent scholarship recognizes movement participants' rationality and treats emotions as pervasive aspects of social life that are important to collective action and changes in protest dynamics.[16]

For our study, this work is relevant specifically because it directs attention to how political speeches, media images, and publicly expressed emotions frame participation. These issues connect to the political statements, footage of dispersals, and collective slogans discussed by our interviewees, allowing us to examine how public representations and emotional responses were linked to mobilization in this case.

The cultural turn and the conflicts of the previous century renewed scholarly attention to emotions in social movements. Historically, research on emotions followed two broad approaches: one emphasized physiological and biological aspects, while the other emphasized

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[13] Theodore D. Kemper, ed., *Research Agendas in the Sociology of Emotions* (State University of New York Press, 1990), 27–31.
[14] Theodore D. Kemper, ed., *Research Agendas in the Sociology of Emotions* (State University of New York Press, 1990), 27–31.
[15] Theodore D. Kemper, ed., *Research Agendas in the Sociology of Emotions* (State University of New York Press, 1990), 27–31.
[16] Janet Staiger, Ann Cvetkovich, and Ann Reynolds, eds., *Political Emotions* (Routledge, 2010).

social relationships and environmental conditions. Emotions were often equated with irrationality and treated as incompatible with reason. Fear and anger were particularly associated with social movements, although shame, pride, love, hatred, and surprise also influence them.

Beyond the division between social and physiological approaches, emotions were primarily studied from the standpoint of the individual. This generated two central questions: how are individual emotions transformed within social movements, and how are new emotions created collectively? The second question provides a starting point for understanding collective behavior consistent with Émile Durkheim's view that its explanation requires a social, rather than solely individual, point of departure.

As social forces grounded in values, movements express structures of feeling that organize and shape ways of life. In this sense, they can be understood as emerging cultures that transform and develop values and emotions. Emotions are ways of experiencing values. They generate responses that lead to action, connecting them to social movements and other forms of collective action. Movements can create and direct collective emotions toward particular purposes, and emotions as different as fear and love may contribute to a sense of collectivity.[17]

**Theoretical Framework**

Our theoretical framework treats emotions as processes that can motivate, guide, or inhibit action, drawing on Jasper's account in *The Emotions of Protest*. In "The Emotions of Protest: Affective and Reactive Emotions In and Around Social Movements," Jasper argues that emotions matter at every stage of protest. They can initially motivate people to participate,[18] while new emotions also emerge during the protest itself.[19] This distinction is important because emotions may change markedly during demonstrations and thereby alter movement dynamics. We therefore distinguish between emotions that initially motivated participation and those that remained in the background throughout the protests. These processes may influence whether a movement continues and what form its continuation takes.

Examining which emotions brought people together and encouraged greater involvement can help explain how emotional processes contribute to movement organization.

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[17] Helena Flam and Debra King, eds., *Emotions and Social Movements* (Routledge, 2005).
[18] James M. Jasper, "The Emotions of Protest: Affective and Reactive Emotions In and Around Social Movements," Sociological Forum 13, no. 3 (1998): 397–424.
[19] James M. Jasper, "The Emotions of Protest: Affective and Reactive Emotions In and Around Social Movements," Sociological Forum 13, no. 3 (1998): 397–424.

Jasper describes both positive and negative consequences of particular emotions. Anger may be directed in different ways and may disrupt strategies, while shame can provoke an aggressive response.[20] Positive emotions are equally important. Love may create attachment to other participants, while loyalty and solidarity may encourage people to act as members of a group or social category.[21]

Jasper also discusses moods, which are more enduring and may accompany a movement over time, although reflex emotions arising during particular interactions can alter them.[22] Cynicism and depression may impede protest by weakening hopes for change. Fear may paralyze people or turn into anger, whereas joy may attract people to participation and strengthen expectations of a better future.[23]

The issue of retaining participants is directly connected to mobilization and protest dynamics,[24] and often to a movement's success. Jasper examines cultural components that influence participation and, especially, their emotional dimensions.[25] Because participants' attitudes affect protest dynamics, this perspective helps us identify the emotions associated with remaining at the protest site and those associated with leaving. The interaction of positive and negative emotions may encourage people either to join a protest or to withdraw, making attention to both emotions and moods essential.

Social movements involve public action that can be understood as political performance, with expressive and dramatic elements. Such performances evoke emotions both within and beyond a movement as participants pursue their goals. They are public because they address an audience. The performance perspective informed by Goffman, as discussed in the literature on emotions and social movements, directs attention to place, interaction, and the public expression of emotion. In our case, it helps us examine how collective slogans, music, and speeches outside Parliament connected individual feelings to a shared protest experience.

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[20] James M. Jasper, "The Emotions of Protest: Affective and Reactive Emotions In and Around Social Movements," Sociological Forum 13, no. 3 (1998): 397–424.
[21] James M. Jasper, "The Emotions of Protest: Affective and Reactive Emotions In and Around Social Movements," Sociological Forum 13, no. 3 (1998): 397–424.
[22] James M. Jasper, "Emotions and Social Movements: Twenty Years of Theory and Research," Annual Review of Sociology 37 (2011): 285–303.
[23] James M. Jasper, "The Emotions of Protest: Affective and Reactive Emotions In and Around Social Movements," Sociological Forum 13, no. 3 (1998): 397–424.
[24] James M. Jasper, "The Emotions of Protest: Affective and Reactive Emotions In and Around Social Movements," Sociological Forum 13, no. 3 (1998): 397–424.
[25] James M. Jasper, "The Emotions of Protest: Affective and Reactive Emotions In and Around Social Movements," Sociological Forum 13, no. 3 (1998): 397–424.

This perspective assigns an important role to the emotions of both participants and audiences. It helps frame questions about what happens when people take part in a movement, how participation affects individual action, and how individual actions in turn influence collective action and emotion. Social movements emerge when diverse and changing groups of individuals perceive themselves as united by shared goals and views. A collective sense of who "we" are is an important means of evoking emotion and shaping shared public opinion.[26] Our argument is that, in these protests, publicly shared expressions of unity and identity helped sustain participation, while fear arising in confrontations could interrupt it.

The performance perspective provides an analytical framework for examining the connection between individual and collective emotions in social movements. It adds an interactional dimension to the study of cognitive frames and emotions. Although performance may suggest role-playing or a predetermined script, emotions in a movement need not follow a fixed sequence: participants respond to changing situations. This perspective helps relate individual emotions to the shared experiences of those participating in a protest.[27]

It also helps explain how social movements affect individuals' feelings and communicate the values that participants defend. Shared performances can connect participants emotionally and extend the boundaries of empathy. We use this perspective specifically to interpret the collective chanting, music, and public expressions of identity described in the analysis, while Jasper's concepts guide our examination of particular emotions and their changing effects on participation.

## Methodology

### Case Study

Protest is a complex sociopolitical phenomenon that takes different forms, including demonstrations, strikes, and hunger strikes. These forms are familiar in Georgia, whose approximately 30-year democratic history has included numerous episodes of protest. Understanding the role of emotions is important for examining the dynamics of collective action, participants' motivations, and the outcomes of social movements. Mass demonstrations have been a particularly prominent form of protest in Georgia.[28]

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[26] Helena Flam and Debra King, eds., *Emotions and Social Movements* (Routledge, 2005).
[27] Helena Flam and Debra King, eds., *Emotions and Social Movements* (Routledge, 2005).
[28] Jimsher Rekhviashvili, "The Evolution of Protest: What Works and How?," Radio Tavisupleba, July 2, 2019. [In Georgian.]

To examine the protests against the “Russian law,” which spread across the country and drew large numbers of people, we used a case study approach. A major strength of this approach is that it allows researchers to focus closely on a particular case involving several interrelated circumstances or actors. This enabled us to examine aspects of the protests that might otherwise have received less attention.

The case study approach also allowed us to examine how the social, cultural, and political context shaped the emotions experienced and expressed during demonstrations.[29] Its flexibility made it suitable for different stages of the research. We could examine how particular factors, such as politicians’ statements from the podium or changes in the number of protesters at different times, influenced participants’ attitudes.

A case study can capture the complexity of lived experience and help examine possible relationships between emotions, the course of a protest, and its outcomes.[30] Social movements involve multiple actors, events, and emotions, making them difficult to study and interpret. This complexity was particularly relevant in Georgia’s fragile political environment and in relation to a central concern underlying the protests: Russia and its influence in the country. This concern evoked memories of the difficult and violent history of relations between Russia and Georgia, further complicating the relationship between emotions and protest. Attention to context therefore helped us examine how emotions developed and interacted over time, what shaped them, and how their intensity and character changed.

Examining how emotions influenced the behavior of protesters and authorities also offered insight into how different emotional processes might support or hinder the pursuit of protest goals.

We conducted ten semi-structured interviews, using follow-up questions to explore participants’ responses in greater depth when necessary. We sought participants of different genders and ages. The age categories were 18–25, 25–35, and 35+. Participants were recruited through snowball sampling, which involved identifying an initial set of participants and then locating further candidates through their contacts. The interviews lasted approximately 20–30 minutes.

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[29] Sanat Pai Raikar, “Case Study,” Encyclopaedia Britannica.

[30] Mark Murphy, “What Are the Benefits and Drawbacks of Case Study Research?,” Social Theory Applied, May 24, 2014.

Our questions focused on the emotions experienced by protest participants and on how those emotions changed over time. During interviews, we showed participants videos of dispersals and political speeches, observed their reactions, and asked how they felt while watching them.

Questions:

1. How old are you?
2. How many times have you attended protests against the “Russian law”?
3. Why did you consider it necessary to attend the protests?
4. How did you feel when you learned that consideration of the law had resumed a year later? (We show two posts contrasting politicians’ statements about withdrawing the law the previous year and reintroducing it this year.)
5. (We show drone footage of a large crowd.) How do you feel when you watch this footage?
6. How did you feel when all the protesters chanted together, “No to the Russian law, yes to Europe!”?
7. (We show footage of a dispersal.) How do you feel when you watch this footage?
8. What did you expect when you learned that a dispersal was beginning?
9. If the authorities used severe measures to disperse the protest, such as pepper spray, tear gas, or water cannons, would you prefer to leave and resume peacefully the next day, or to stay and engage in civil disobedience?
10. Do you think the struggle is worthwhile? Why?

Alongside the semi-structured interviews, we conducted participant observation during a one-month period of active participation in the protests, primarily outside Parliament. We observed the course of the demonstrations, changes in crowd size, chanting, responses to political speeches, and interactions with the police. This enabled us to examine changes in emotions and attitudes as the protests unfolded. We also conducted four ethnographic interviews, lasting approximately 2–10 minutes, at different points during the demonstrations. These interviews complemented our observations and helped us analyze changes in protest dynamics.

## Data Analysis

Our coding system focused on emotions and related subjective experiences, including unity, pride, anger, disappointment, regret, fear, motivation to struggle, and nihilism. We organized the analysis into two main categories: emotions associated with greater activity and those associated with passivity. The data are presented thematically by emotion to examine how each was associated with protest dynamics. These categories describe tendencies rather than fixed effects, since the same emotion could encourage action in one situation and withdrawal in another.

## Emotions That Encourage Active Participation

Feelings of unity, pride, anger, determination, hope, and disgust encouraged participants to act. They did so in different ways: unity strengthened a sense of belonging, pride and determination connected participation to personal and national identity, and hope sustained a willingness to continue despite setbacks. Anger and disgust directed opposition toward the authorities and, in participants' accounts, encouraged them to return to the protests and withstand pressure. Together, these processes helped sustain participation and influenced the intensity of the demonstrations.

## Unity

In the interviews and participant observation, a sense of unity emerged as a particularly prominent experience. Participants described feeling united when surrounded by people with shared goals and motivations, sometimes likening the crowd to a family. "I physically get goosebumps. It is emotional because I was standing there. I felt the same way then because I experienced that unity. In general, I am not expressive or extroverted, so gathering with people on that scale was very unusual for me. But without the idea that connected me to those people—and I do not doubt this for a second—I might not have overcome that difficulty." Participants felt that this emotion had a positive effect by giving the demonstration energy.

Our observations also suggested a relationship between crowd size and the experience of unity. When numbers declined, chanting became less frequent and people dispersed. These were the observable indicators of declining protest activity. Interviewees' descriptions of the connection between a large crowd, unity, and hope informed our interpretation that falling attendance could

weaken this emotional momentum; observation alone did not establish what each departing participant felt.

Interviewees also reported that shared slogans, such as “Yes to Europe and no to the Russian law,” intensified their sense of unity. “These few words unite all of us, and together we make our voices and our position heard by the world: we do not want the Russian law, and we want Europe. That creates a great deal of hope.”

Smelser’s account of collective behavior identifies structural conduciveness: the conditions that make collective action possible.[31] The unity described in our interviews is more precisely understood as an emotional condition supporting participation, rather than a structural condition in that specific theoretical sense. Participants’ accounts and our observations suggest that unity helped sustain the duration, intensity, and dynamics of the demonstrations.

**Hope**

Protests involve striving toward a shared goal and struggling to achieve it. The protests against the “Russian law” continued for a considerable period, during which we observed several developments. Across successive parliamentary hearings, people hoped that they were moving closer to their goal, but these hopes were repeatedly disappointed when the parliamentary majority supported the bill. Participants feared that the public might eventually lose hope and give up. Disappointment therefore posed a risk to continued participation, even though the interviewees in our study still intended to keep struggling in the hope of a better future.

Several participants drew on historical experience to explain this commitment. They noted that Georgia had faced many critical periods but had ultimately prevailed. “The struggle is always worthwhile, and I think that because of our history. Our ancestors, as far as we know from history, were probably in worse situations. If they had thought that struggling was pointless, Georgia would not have survived to this day. That is why I think the struggle is always worthwhile; making the effort is worthwhile.” The phrase “the struggle is always worthwhile” recurred across many interviews and was directly connected to hope for the future.

Some participants also linked the erosion of hope to fear and ridicule. They described cynical attitudes on the part of the authorities alongside the violence witnessed during the demonstrations. Jasper discusses how more enduring feelings, including hope, may be affected by reflex emotions.[32] In this case, fear could undermine hope. Nevertheless, participants said

[31] James S. Ormrod, *Fantasy and Social Movements* (Palgrave Macmillan, 2014).

[32] James M. Jasper, “Emotions and Social Movements: Twenty Years of Theory and Research,” Annual Review of Sociology 37 (2011): 285–303.

they would remain steadfast despite the pressure and that these factors did not deter them. “I think people will not give up under any circumstances, and we will still win.”

**Anger and Disgust**

If one emotion could be identified as a principal driving force behind the protests we studied, it would be anger. Although anger can take the form of a short-lived reflex emotion,[33] in this case its influence appeared to help sustain the energy of a protest that continued for more than a month. Anger was a shared emotion among participants, and almost all interviewees identified anger toward the government as a motivation for becoming involved.

*“Anger was the feeling that intensified most. Although I expected the government to act this way, what I felt most strongly was anger that the government is lying to us and trying to convince us that the law is not Russian and brings us closer to a European future.”*

Anger was thus a major motivation for people to take to the streets and protest against the situation. It was also important to examine whether this emotion persisted throughout the demonstrations.

Participants reported that anger accumulated from day to day, particularly when they watched footage of dispersals, and that its influence did not diminish. They explained that the anger they felt after seeing such footage reinforced their conviction that the protests had to continue every day.

“I was not there during the major dispersals, when they chased people from street to street. I remember people around me, my friends, saying that we were definitely going the next day because of what we had seen the previous evening. It was a moment of overcoming fear: you become even angrier because you have witnessed such great injustice.”

Participant observation complemented these interview accounts. We observed marked increases in attendance on the day after dispersals, a pattern that recurred following incidents of police violence. Anger was also reflected in participants’ behavior. Instead of leaving areas where violence appeared possible or dispersing, many remained firmly in place and resisted pressure. Read alongside the interviews, these observations suggest that anger contributed to their willingness to stand their ground.

Anger therefore appeared to form part of the emotional background of this protest movement. Reflexive, uncontrolled anger can potentially disrupt strategic action,[34] but the anger described by our respondents was connected to perceived injustice. In their accounts, this connection

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[33] James M. Jasper, *The Emotions of Protest* (University of Chicago Press, 2018), 34.

[34] James M. Jasper, “Emotions and Social Movements: Twenty Years of Theory and Research,” Annual Review of Sociology 37 (2011): 287.

supported continued and more sustained action rather than simply an immediate reaction. This distinction helps explain why anger could remain influential throughout the demonstrations.

Anger can be understood as a negative shared emotion. Yet our observations, particularly during participant observation, suggested that anger toward opponents was accompanied by positive emotions among protesters. This strengthened their sense of collectivity and encouraged more active involvement.[35] Anger toward the police, for example, was accompanied by sympathy for those detained and a desire to support them financially and morally. In this way, anger helped connect participants to one another.

The theoretical discussion of anger highlights the possibility that it may disrupt political action when it overwhelms strategic judgment.[36] Our findings, however, emphasize a different possibility: anger linked to perceived injustice became a sustained and prominent motivation that helped maintain mobilization. This is a finding about the particular protests studied, rather than a claim that anger always has this effect.

Disgust appeared to share some of the mobilizing effects of anger. We interpreted this emotion through participants' accounts and conduct observed at the protest site. People standing in front of riot police shouted labels such as "slaves" and "enemies of the country." The tone and content of these expressions suggested disgust, although they did not allow us to exclude anger or fear. Similar expressions directed at the government and police appeared on the walls of Parliament.

David Livingstone Smith's account of dehumanization, discussed by Jasper, concerns the use of labels that portray others as less than human.[37] In our case, one such expression of disgust toward the police was "dogs." The riot officers' masks also concealed their identities. We interpreted this concealment in relation to the hostility expressed toward them, although observation alone could not establish the officers' reasons for wearing masks. Interviewees reported that their negative feelings toward law enforcement also arose when they saw officers outside the protests.

"I develop this unpleasant feeling toward them, because I do not think that none of them understands what is happening. I do not believe that every riot officer standing there sincerely thinks they are defending the law or the right policy. They understand where everything is heading and whose government they serve. They know they are serving Russia's government, and they carry on anyway. Those who understand and still do the same things, who treat an

[35] James M. Jasper, "Emotions and Social Movements: Twenty Years of Theory and Research," Annual Review of Sociology 37 (2011): 294.
[36] James M. Jasper, *The Emotions of Protest* (University of Chicago Press, 2018), 35–36.
[37] James M. Jasper, *The Emotions of Protest* (University of Chicago Press, 2018), 47.

innocent person like that, are worse than this government. They fall into an even worse category."

Disgust thus extended beyond the protest site and contributed, in participants' accounts, to stigmatizing law enforcement. Interviewees described it as a motivation to oppose the police and express their dissatisfaction by standing directly in front of them at demonstrations. Our observations were consistent with this account: confrontation was particularly intense where riot police were deployed, allowing protesters to direct their emotions toward them.

Although disgust might be expected to discourage contact or participation in some circumstances, in this case it appeared to increase participants' determination. Disgust toward law enforcement was associated with a desire to restore justice through opposition, to take to the streets, and to remain outside Parliament. In this sense, it supported mobilization and contributed to the intensity of the demonstrations.

**Pride and Determination**

Thoits distinguishes a strong version of social constructionism, which rejects the existence of basic universal emotions, from a weaker version, which allows that basic emotions may exist but cannot explain the whole picture. Basic emotions, such as anger and surprise, may be more universal and more directly connected to bodily states, whereas complex feelings, such as pride and determination, may depend more heavily on cultural context. Basic emotions may also be especially important in face-to-face interactions, while secondary emotions, such as indignation or pride, may have greater influence in ongoing political processes.[38]

Some respondents initially identified anger as the emotion that prompted them to attend demonstrations, but their accounts also connected this response to a deeper feeling that their pride had been wounded. As demonstrations became routine, anger could develop into more enduring feelings. "Anger is a momentary thing. You cannot stay angry all the time. At some point that emotion passes, and then you have to direct that anger in the right way, and the result will come." In these accounts, directing anger involved a sense of pride: the actions being protested were experienced as an affront because participants' words, opinions, and wishes were disregarded.

Jasper also discusses collective identity, an important concept for analyzing protest. Defining oneself through a collective label involves both an affective and a cognitive understanding of the social world. Partly for this reason, taking part in a movement can itself be rewarding,

[38] James M. Jasper, "The Emotions of Protest: Affective and Reactive Emotions In and Around Social Movements," Sociological Forum 13, no. 3 (1998): 397–424.

independently of its ultimate goals or outcomes. One respondent explained: “When I watch this footage, my first response is to smile and feel proud. I also know what it means to be part of it yourself, in person, right there. It is a different kind of unity and pride. You feel so strong together with so many people, all shouting ‘Georgia!’ That is when I feel how much we love this country and how much we can do.”

Another response concerned protest symbols, specifically the music played at demonstrations: “The Georgian national anthem stays with me, and all of this is contagious. Whenever it starts playing, I immediately feel excited. Sometimes I also feel privileged, because you know what this means, and you want someone who does not know to experience it too. You want absolutely everyone to experience all of it.” Through the performance perspective outlined above, these shared songs and chants can be interpreted as public expressions of identity that connect individual pride to a collective experience.

Protest becomes a way of expressing something about oneself and one’s moral commitments and of taking pride in them. The strength of an identity derives partly from its emotional dimension. Identities can remain conceptually imprecise while still being strongly defended, often through feelings of pride. Collective emotions at demonstrations are therefore also connected to enjoyment, especially the pleasure of being with people with whom one shares something. Collective activities, including movement, singing, and chanting, may be rewarding even among strangers, whose sense of unfamiliarity can diminish through shared action.

Expressing one’s moral principles can also evoke joy and pride amid negative events. Participants said: “Overall, I am proud of all these protests,” and, “I feel proud and tears come to my eyes. You know, I have noticed that during the demonstrations everyone looks beautiful to me, every young person. I see them afterward too, on the same streets and on the same transport, but here they are beautiful in a different way. I feel like crying and I feel proud at the same time. It gives me great hope that you really can do everything and work wonders.”

Jasper’s concept of the moral battery is relevant here. It describes how tension or contrast between positive and negative emotions can motivate action. An emotion can become more intense when explicitly or implicitly compared with its opposite, much as a battery operates through the tension between its positive and negative poles. Pride and shame are a frequently studied example, particularly in LGBTQ rights movements, where activists seek to foster pride in place of shame.[39]

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[39] James M. Jasper, “Emotions and Social Movements: Twenty Years of Theory and Research,” Annual Review of Sociology 37 (2011): 291.

Pride is often evoked by emphasizing identity. Historical narratives also played an important role in these protests. Speakers frequently repeated the words of Zurab Zhvania, Merab Kostava, and Zviad Gamsakhurdia, figures associated with independence or the struggle for freedom and held in high esteem. Recalling these figures and highlighting historical symbols could evoke pride, sustain the energy of the demonstrations, and motivate participants.

One respondent explained: “I have had a sense of protest since childhood. Then there were various protests, and April 9 was the most tragic. So what brought me to the demonstration was the desire for freedom and the regret that we did not manage to leave you a country in which you would not have to stand here now. It is our fault. We were not good enough, but you are the best, and you will be able to bring about change. That is why I think I should stand here, and I do, together with my 15-year-old grandchild.”

Pride could develop into a shared determination that gave the protests continuity. Because this feeling involved personal and national identity, participants did not view giving up as an option and continued to believe that the struggle was worthwhile. “Well, I have always wanted to resist. There has always been this protest inside me, a sense that something was wrong. But now, since the demonstrations began, you know, I have wanted to live again. Somehow it is as if I have come back to life. So yes, the struggle is always worthwhile.”

**Emotions That Encourage Passivity**

Our study also identified emotions and subjective states associated with reduced protest activity, including disappointment, fear, regret, nihilism, and alienation. These could diminish participants’ energy, although, as the following accounts show, their effects were not uniform and could sometimes also encourage renewed action.

**Fear**

During the protests against the “Russian law,” participants described several instances in which the authorities used severe measures, including water cannons, pepper spray, rubber bullets, and tear gas. Such forms of dispersal could understandably evoke fear and encourage withdrawal. Some participants said that, during dispersals, they preferred to leave the area temporarily and resume protesting peacefully. Others said that fear intensified their anger, increased their courage, energized them, and made them feel ready to overcome resistance.

“You are afraid, but you do not give up. You push harder. You cannot retreat; you will not give up, and you will move further forward. It is just an instinctive fear, something imprinted in your mind that tells you that you should be afraid in that situation. But that fear does not make you stop. It does not hold you back. On the contrary, it makes you more active and pushes you

forward: go on, do not retreat. You have the right to do this. You are doing it for the country, for democracy, for a brighter future."

Despite many such accounts, our observations also showed reduced activity during dispersals because some people chose to withdraw. As discussed in the section on unity, declining numbers could diminish the crowd's energy. This was also evident in these situations.

The performance perspective discussed above directs attention to how visible interactions between individuals affect the wider protest setting and its collective emotional atmosphere.[40] During participant observation, we saw that when officers pursued a particular person or attempted an arrest, sudden confusion arose and tension spread through the crowd. Many participants appeared frightened and immediately moved away.

One participant explained that, on seeing a crowd moving toward them, they followed it without knowing what was happening and felt an instinctive need to escape. "All you hear is the pounding of feet as people run, and you think you have to follow them too. You do not know what is happening—or rather, you cannot process it—but you have to follow, because these are your people and you know you have to follow them." These observations show how individual actions became public cues for collective responses. The immediate spread of fear is, however, more directly explained through reflex emotions than through performance alone.

Jasper's account of reflex emotions is consistent with this observation. Rapid fear that spreads through a crowd can interrupt active protest by prompting people to retreat.[41]

**Nihilism and Alienation**

Prolonged protests are often accompanied by a loss of hope, exhaustion, and withdrawal. Our interviews identified two additional experiences: nihilism and alienation. Nihilistic attitudes were directed primarily toward the government and its decisions, rather than toward the demonstrations themselves or other participants' responses. One respondent distinguished this attitude from disappointment, explaining that it was impossible to lose hope when one had none in the first place. They had expected the government's decision and had never believed that it would take meaningful steps toward Europe.

Participants often appeared prepared for what happened: almost none expressed surprise. In their view, the government had disappointed the public so many times that this episode was no exception.

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[40] Helena Flam and Debra King, eds., *Emotions and Social Movements* (Routledge, 2005).

[41] James M. Jasper, "Emotions and Social Movements: Twenty Years of Theory and Research," Annual Review of Sociology 37 (2011): 285–303.

Nihilism was also intertwined with anger related to the previous year's events. This anger was directed not only at others but also at oneself for failing to secure the desired outcome. One respondent questioned the meaning of the previous year's success: why had people celebrated, stood there, and exposed themselves to rubber bullets and water cannons? The recurring question was, "What was the point?" This expressed a profound sense of futility: why had people put their lives aside if nothing would change and they would return to the same starting point?

Alienation appeared in one interview. The respondent described feeling disconnected from other protesters' emotions and attitudes during the president's speech. The crowd responded optimistically, but the respondent found nothing positive in the occasion.

These interviews identified emotions that could intensify or diminish the energy of demonstrations. They also showed that people interpreted the same event differently and therefore experienced different emotional responses, an important consideration throughout our analysis.

**Disappointment and Regret**

Disappointment and regret emerged when participants described a gap between their expectations and the reality they encountered. Although many said they expected little from a government that had repeatedly disappointed them, their responses to footage of dispersals were different. During interviews, participants watched several recordings in which officers physically assaulted people. Disappointment was a prominent initial response.

Many respondents associated the severity of the violence with dehumanization. "It is unimaginable when a brother turns against a brother, a man turns against a woman, hits her mercilessly, drags her along the ground, tears her hair. No matter how much I want to believe that these people too… are human beings, and that they are in that system and in this country to protect us…"

Disappointment was followed by sorrow over what was being done to people and over peaceful demonstrations becoming sites of violence where participants had little opportunity to defend themselves. "This is violence, deliberate violence, often directed at particular people. It is simply very sad that we have to endure and live through this."

Although these emotions were most apparent after participants watched footage of dispersals, they also arose in other contexts. One respondent described feeling disappointed by low attendance at demonstrations. Disappointment was sometimes mixed with fear: after the

decision to proceed with the “Russian law,” respondents feared that the country was heading in the wrong direction, toward the north, and anticipated the consequences of such an orientation.

In this case, disappointment also contributed to mobilization. As noted earlier, the law’s reintroduction initially disappointed many individuals and helped prompt the collective action of demonstrations attended by thousands. Disappointment could therefore be an initial motivation for action as well as a source of diminished energy. Regret and sorrow also shaped participants’ perceptions of their circumstances and weakened expectations that the authorities would protect them. Interviewees described the government and law enforcement as willing to use severe force to achieve their aims regardless of who was affected.

Disappointment and regret thus helped shape the dynamics of the protests against the “Russian law.” Their effects were not limited to passivity: they could also encourage action and contribute to the formation of shared goals and narratives.

**Conclusion**

Our findings suggest that emotions shaped participation in the protests against the “Russian law” through several distinct processes. Anger in response to political decisions was a principal initial motivation for attending demonstrations. As the protests continued, feelings of unity encouraged active involvement, while pride and emotions connected to personal and national identity helped sustain participation. These emotional processes were associated with both mobilization and changes in protest dynamics.

Other emotions could discourage participation, particularly in response to severe dispersal measures, psychological pressure, disinformation, and attacks on participants in particular locations. Fear sometimes prompted withdrawal and reduced the crowd’s energy, while in other accounts it intensified anger and determination. Negative emotions did not uniformly extinguish hope: many respondents remained committed to continuing, even where nihilism toward the government or feelings of alienation were also present.

The duration of the protests also appeared to shape how participants experienced their emotions. Immediate reactions, including anger and disgust, could become connected to more enduring feelings and commitments. This helped explain how emotions initially associated with particular events continued to support sustained participation.

Our study also identified effects beyond the protest site. Participants described carrying these emotions into everyday life, learning to live with them, and attempting to suppress them.

**Limitations**

This study examined protests against the “Russian law,” so its findings cannot be assumed to apply to every type of demonstration. It also focused primarily on the area outside Parliament.

We encountered several difficulties during the research. Many people declined ethnographic interviews because they were concerned about anonymity. During participant observation, the chaotic and tense environment made it difficult to describe critical moments in detail. Police pressure also impeded documentation, including interference with filming and the deletion of photographs. People sometimes avoided us when they saw a camera or note-taking materials. Most people approached for ethnographic interviews preferred to remain anonymous and wanted a clear explanation of who we were and why we were conducting the research.

We were also participants in the demonstrations, which may have influenced our interpretations and led us to view events from the protesters’ perspective. The emotions that arose during the protests affected our own emotional states and sometimes made it difficult to maintain critical distance.

The combination of interviews and participant observation nevertheless allowed us to examine both participants’ accounts and the unfolding dynamics of the protests. A next step would be to compare how unity, anger, fear, and hope shaped participation at other sites within the same protest movement, such as Europe Square and Heroes’ Square. This would allow us to explore whether location influenced the emotional atmosphere and the intensity of participation.

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